Cover letter — Data Mining and Knowledge Discovery (DMKD, Springer)

Date: 17 July 2026

Dear Prof. Hüllermeier, Editor-in-Chief,

We submit our manuscript, "Group- and Time-Split Coverage in Tabular Models Fails to Certify, but Uncertainty Abstention Robustly Repairs Selective Risk: A Preregistered Audit with Held-Out Confirmatory Replication," for consideration in *Data Mining and Knowledge Discovery*.

Tabular models are routinely validated with random splits, but deployment shifts are usually grouped — a new entity, region, or time period. Across 14 public OpenML datasets carrying an entity or time key, and a preregistered, held-out confirmatory replication on TableShift, the paper shows two things. First, moving to leave-group-out or rolling-origin splits leaves split-conformal coverage below its nominal target, and no tested distribution-free remedy restores it at the majority level. Second, the repairable part is selective risk: uncertainty-ranked abstention beats random deferral on 13 of 14 datasets, model-agnostically across gradient-boosted models and tabular foundation models, surviving multiplicity correction and confirmed without exception on the held-out tasks. The resulting prescription is deliberately minimal — plain split-conformal plus uncertainty abstention, scoped to selective reliability rather than a coverage guarantee.

As a benchmark-and-audit study with a preregistered confirmatory arm and honestly reported negative results, we believe the paper sits squarely in DMKD's tradition of rigorous evaluation and benchmark contributions. The manuscript states its preregistration outcomes plainly, including which counts are confirmatory and which are exploratory.

This manuscript is original work and is not under consideration elsewhere.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

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